

BRACING FOR THE FIGHT
SP chief Akhilesh Yadav at an event in Lucknow, Mar. 19; (right) West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee during a TMC rally in Kolkata, Mar. 10



HINDUSTAN TIMES

IN UP AND BIHAR, I.N.D.I.A. ALLIES HOPE TO ENCASH THE CASTE CARD, WHILE IN BENGAL, MAMATA HOPES TO WIN BY THE FORCE OF HER PERSONALITY

year to a woman in every poor family, 50 per cent quota for women in central government recruitment, legal status to MSP and a national minimum wage of Rs 400 a day. To take its message to the masses, Kharge launched the 'Ghar Ghar Guarantee' initiative on April 3 to reach out to 80 million households.

The Congress's third strategy is to field new candidates, not just in seats where it directly faces the BJP but across the country. Of the 228 candidates announced up to April 2, 150, or 66 per cent, were replacements for the 2019 contestants. Merit, though, has not always been the consideration. The GOP still relies on dynastic politics, with more than 30 candidates being the progeny of senior Congress leaders. Additionally, many of its leaders seem to be shying away from contesting themselves—be it Ashok Gehlot, Bhupinder Singh Hooda, Jitendra Singh or even Kharge and Sonia, who have recused themselves on account of age.

Meanwhile, the spate of desertions do little to ameliorate the sinking feeling. Just ahead of the polls, several big-ticket leaders such as Ashok Chavan and Milind Deora in Maharashtra, Suresh Pachouri in MP, Arjun Modhwadia in Gujarat, Ravneet Singh Bittu in Punjab and Naveen Jindal in Haryana have left to join the BJP. Such defections, whether brought on by fears of probes by central agencies or the prospects of a reward by the BJP, inspire scant confidence among other I.N.D.I.A. constituents in the Congress being a force of any kind. The party's recent losses in the assembly polls in MP, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh have only deepened the demoralisation.

BIG REGIONAL BATTLEZONES

The real test for I.N.D.I.A. will be in four key battleground states—Uttar Pradesh (80 seats), Maharashtra (48), West Bengal (42) and Bihar (40)—which together account for 210 seats. However, instead of combining their forces in these states, the I.N.D.I.A. bloc allowed the BJP to significantly dilute their challenge. In UP, where the Opposition parties won only 16 of the state's 80 seats in 2019, the BJP has systematically diminished the influence of the Samajwadi Party led by Akhilesh Yadav, who had fashioned a rainbow alliance against it in the 2022 assembly polls. The BJP has now won over two of the party's key allies—Jayant Chaudhary's RLD (Rashtriya Lok Dal), which has Jat support in the west, and Om Prakash Rajbhar's SBSP (Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party), which holds sway among the backwards and Dalits. With the Mayawati-led Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) going it alone (instead of with the SP as in 2019)—I.N.D.I.A.'s vote share is open to further erosion.

To counter the BJP's consolidation of votes from non-Yadav OBC groups and Dalits, the SP has been trying to create a social coalition it calls PDA—Pichhde (backward classes or OBCs), Dalits (SCs) and Alpasankhyak (minorities). Rahul, too, is targeting the OBC vote with his pitch for a nationwide caste count. But while they cater to the caste arithmetic, the Opposition cannot be assured of electoral gains for